Recognizing uses of anti-Muslim materials from outside Myanmar illustrates that relations of religious antagonism are not necessarily predetermined and ossified in Myanmar. This is not to say that anti-Muslim sentiments have never been articulated in Myanmar — that is manifestly not the case. But just as it is possible to trace long histories of anti-Muslim sentiments in Europe and note novelties in their contemporary mobilization (Mastnak 2010), so too can this be done in Myanmar. Such relations, as Gyanendra Pandey has argued, are never static: they have histories that can be charted (1998, p. xiv). And as this history is made, there are myriad ways outsiders can contribute to violence — as with my friend's articulation of concern over the issuing of a "killing licence". This concern applies to the fearmongering and threat construction of industries of Islamophobia discussed above, but it also applies to more subtle ways that such materials may be injected into an unfolding conflict. A good example of this would be the controversy over Myanmar's first national census in thirty years, which pitted members of civil society and some international non-governmental organizations against the government and backers of the census process, including the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA) (Htun Htun Min 2014; ICG 2014; Transnational Institute and Burma Centre Netherlands 2014). These groups raised a variety of concerns, including that the decision to include an enumeration of ethnic and religious categories in the census might be used to fuel narratives of demographic vulnerability and encroachment.

Any national census is ambitious, all the more so when conducted for the first time after an extended period, so I do not mean to make any claim here about the particular reasons it was conducted, when, and how it was accomplished. However, considering conversations — debates — regarding the census with its foreign backers in Yangon are nonetheless instructive. My place was not at the centre of these debates but, finding myself unexpectedly in one with a UNFPA employee, I also heard concerns about senses of demographic vulnerability dismissed with an irritated abruptness: "People who are going to hate each other already feel that way and the census won't change anything." The assumption in operation was that Buddhists and Muslims are already at odds and that, more importantly for the discussion in this chapter, proffering new semiotic materials could not alter this. And while, again, we should beware any analysis that treats dynamics in Myanmar as primarily derivative, I hope this chapter has made clear that the boundaries between "people who hate each other" are